

DOLLY'S BOOK

Sourdough starter care and bread recipes

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ABOUT DOLLY

Dolly was started from scratch in September 2021 using King Arthur bread flour and filtered tap water. Named after Dolly Parton because she is resilient, adaptable, and occasionally dramatic. She lives in a quart mason jar on the counter, covered with a cloth napkin. She is now four years old and running strong.

Flour: I switched to 50/50 King Arthur All-Purpose and whole wheat in 2023. More flavor.

Water: Asheville tap is fine. If she seems sluggish in summer, try filtered.

Feeding schedule: 1:1:1 by weight when baking weekly. If not baking, refrigerator and feed once a week, discard all but 50g, add 50g flour and 50g water.

Signs she is happy: doubles within 4 to 6 hours of feeding, domed top, lots of bubbles, smells like yogurt and apples. If she smells like acetone, she is hungry. Feed immediately. Signs of trouble: orange or pink streaks (contamination, start over), liquid sitting on top for more than 12 hours (underfed, increase frequency).

BASIC COUNTRY LOAF

Makes one 900g boule. Active time 45 minutes. Total time 26 to 30 hours.

INGREDIENTS

450g King Arthur Bread Flour (or 400g bread, 50g whole wheat)

325g filtered water at 75 to 80 degrees F

90g active starter (fed 4 to 6 hours earlier, at peak)

9g fine sea salt (not iodized)

PROCESS

Night before (8 to 10 PM):

Mix flour and 300g of the water until no dry flour remains. Cover and rest 45 minutes.

This is the autolyse. Do not add starter or salt yet.

Add starter and salt, then work in the remaining 25g water a little at a time.

Pinch and fold until the dough feels cohesive. It will be slightly sticky. That is okay.

Cover and set a timer for 30 minutes.

Bulk ferment (4 to 5 hours at 72 to 74 degrees F):

Every 30 minutes for the first 2 hours, do a set of stretch and folds: grab the dough at one side, stretch it up and fold it over itself. Rotate the bowl 90 degrees. Repeat 4 times.

After 4 sets, leave it alone. The dough is done when it is airy, jiggling, and has grown

about 50 percent.

Pre-shape and bench rest:

Turn dough onto an unfloured counter. Use a bench scraper to shape it loosely into a round. Let it rest uncovered 20 to 30 minutes until it relaxes into a flat disk.

Final shape:

Flour a proofing basket (banneton) or a bowl lined with a lightly floured linen.

Flip the dough, pull the edges toward the center in overlapping folds, then flip seam-side down. Use the scraper to drag it toward you to build surface tension.

Place seam-side up in the proofing basket.

Cold proof:

Cover tightly with a plastic bag or beeswax wrap. Refrigerate 12 to 16 hours.

Overnight is ideal. The cold proof builds flavor.

Bake day:

One hour before baking, place Dutch oven in the oven and preheat to 500 degrees F.

Remove dough from refrigerator, flip onto parchment, score with a lame or sharp razor.

A single slash at 45 degrees works fine. The ear forms where the blade undercuts the dough.

Lower dough into the screaming hot Dutch oven on the parchment. Put the lid on.

Bake covered 20 minutes at 500 degrees F.

Remove lid. Lower to 450 degrees F.

Bake uncovered 20 to 25 minutes until deep mahogany. Internal temp 205 to 210 degrees F.

Cool completely before cutting. At least 1 hour. The crumb continues to set as it cools.

Cutting early gives a gummy crumb. Wait.

STORAGE

Counter in a cloth bag or cut side down for 2 days.

After that, slice and freeze in a zip bag. Toast directly from frozen.

NOTES BY DATE

October 2021: First successful loaf. Dense but edible. Starter was young.

January 2022: Switched to cold proof method. Flavor improved significantly.

March 2023: Added whole wheat to flour blend. Nuttier flavor, slightly tighter crumb.

November 2024: Focaccia batch with rosemary from the porch. Best batch so far.

February 2025: Dolly survived a full month in the fridge over a busy stretch. Fed, revived, baked.

January 2026: Made two loaves for Loretta's visit. She asked for the recipe. This notebook is it.